

Session 23: God's Covenant With Noah

Key Takeaways

- Noah's drunkenness recalls the foolish failure of the man and woman in the garden of Eden.
- Ham's crime against his family recalls both the failure of Genesis 3 and the escalation of Genesis 4.
- Ham's crime against his family was some form of illicit sexual abuse. The maternal incest (i.e., rape) interpretation of Ham's sin accounts for both the severity of Noah's response and the curse on Canaan.

Noah's Garden and a Family Failure: Translation and Literary Design of Genesis 9:18-29

Noah's Sons: Shem, Ham (= Canaan), and Japheth

- ¹⁸ And the sons of Noah who came out of the ark were **Shem** and **Ham** and **Japheth** ; and **Ham was the father of Canaan** .
- ¹⁹ These three were the sons of Noah, and from these all the land was scattered.

Noah

- ²⁰ **And Noah** began to be a man of the ground and he planted a vineyard;
- ²¹ **and he drank of the wine and became drunk** , and he uncovered himself in the middle of his tent.

Noah's Sons: Ham (= Canaan), Shem and Japheth

- a ²² And **Ham, the father of Canaan** ,
- b **saw the nakedness of his father** ,
-
- a and he reported to **his two brothers** outside.
- b ²³ And **Shem** and **Japheth** took a garment
- a' and they laid it upon the shoulders of **the two of them** ,
-
- a and they walked **backward**

- b and they **covered the nakedness of their father** ;
a' and their faces were **backward** ,
b' and the **nakedness of their father they did not see** .

Noah

- 24 **And Noah awoke from his wine** ,
and he knew what his younger son had done to him;

Noah's Sons: Ham (= Canaan), Shem, and Japheth

- 25 and he said,
a "Cursed be **Canaan** ;
b a servant of servants he will be to his brothers."

- 26 And he said,
a "Blessed be Yahweh the Elohim of **Shem** ,
b and let **Canaan** be his servant.

- a 27 May Elohim enlarge **Japheth** ,
a and let him dwell in the tents of **Shem** ,
b and let **Canaan** be his servant."

Noah

- 28 **And Noah** lived, after the flood, three hundred and fifty years.
29 And all the days of Noah were nine hundred and fifty years,
and he died.

Genesis 9:18-29. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Adam to Noah (2020).

Notice the alternating panels going back and forth between the actions and life of Noah and the actions and future destiny of his sons.

The focus on Ham is in reality a focus on Ham's son Canaan, a connection that will be unpacked only in the following chapter (see Gen. 10:6). It's as if Ham's actions toward his father are an archetype of his descendants' behavior (see Lev. 18 and Lev. 20).

Noah's Three Scattered Sons (Gen. 9:18-19)

The author draws attention to the brothers coming out of the ark as one family, yet after leaving the ark, they are divided and scattered (just as Cain and Abel/Seth left Eden and were divided).

The link between the division of Cain and Abel/Seth and the division of Noah’s sons is reinforced by the intentional parallelism between the line of Cain leading to Lemek and his three sons in Genesis 4:17-26 and the line of Seth leading to Noah and his three sons in Genesis 5:1-32 and 9:18-19.

Cain’s Line Leads to the Flood	Seth’s Line Leads to the Scattering of Babylon
1. Adam 2. Cain 3. Enoch 4. Lyrad 5. Mehuya'el 6. Methusha’el 7. Lemek + 3 sons □ <i>Yabal</i> □ <i>Yubal</i> □ <i>Tubal-Cain</i>	1. Adam 2. Seth 3. Enosh 4. Cainan 5. Mahalelel 6. Yered 7. Enoch 8. Methushelah 9. Lemek 10. Noah + 3 sons □ <i>Shem</i> □ <i>Ham</i> □ <i>Japheth</i>
“Yabal, the father of (אבי) tent-dwellers and livestock” (Gen. 4:20) “Yubal, the father of (אבי) all handlers of lyre and flute” (Gen 4:21)	“Ham, the father of (אבי) Canaan” (Gen. 9:18) “Ham, the father of (אבי) Canaan” (Gen. 9:22)
Followed by the episode about sons of God and human women (Gen. 6:1-4)	Followed by the episode about Ham exploiting his father’s nakedness (Gen. 9:21-24)
... resulting in the flood (<i>mabbul</i> / מבוֹל)	... resulting in a curse, that will lead to the scattering of Babylon (<i>babel</i> / בבל)
<i>Noah’s Three Scattered Sons.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

The mention of “scattering” in Genesis 9:19 is the first use of a key word-matrix: *naphats* (נפץ) and *puts* (פוץ). These are among the standard words used later in the Prophets to describe Israel’s exile among the nations, out of which a remnant (like Noah) will return to Zion.

Isaiah 11:11-12 NASB*

¹¹ Then it will happen on that day that the Lord will again recover the second time with his hand, the remnant of his people who will remain, from Assyria, Egypt, Pathros, Cush, Elam, Shinar, Hamath, and from the islands of the sea.

¹² And he will lift up a standard for the nations

and assemble **the scattered ones** (נפֿין) of Israel,
and will gather **the dispersed ones** (פֿוין) of Judah
from the four corners of the earth.

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

Ezekiel 11:17 NIV

Therefore say: “This is what the Sovereign LORD says: I will gather you from the nations and bring you back from the countries where you have been **scattered** (פֿוין), and I will give you back the land of Israel again.”

Zechariah 13:7 NIV

“Awake, sword, against my shepherd, against the man who is close to me!” declares the LORD Almighty.
“Strike the shepherd, and the sheep will be **scattered** (פֿוין), and I will turn my hand against the little ones.”

This “scattered” language is a united thread that extends all the way from Genesis 9:18-19 to the conclusion of the scattering at Babylon.

9:18-19	And the sons of Noah who went out from the ark: Shem, Ham, and Japheth ... and from these (מאלה) all the land (כל הארץ) was scattered (פֿוין)		
	10:5	And from these (מאלה) were separated (פרד) the islands of the nations	
		10:18	And afterward the families of the Canaanites were scattered (פֿוין)
		10:25	And to Eber two sons were born, the name of the first was Peleg, because in his days the land (הארץ) was divided (נפלגה)
	10:32	These are the families of the sons of Noah by their generations with their nations, and from these (מאלה) the nations were separated (פרד) in the land (בארץ) after the flood.	
		11:4	“Come let’s build for ourselves a city ... lest we be scattered (פֿוין) upon the surface of all the land (כל הארץ)
		11:8	And Yahweh scattered them (פֿוין) from there upon the surface of all the land (כל הארץ)
11:9	Therefore the name was called Babylon, because there Yahweh confused the language of all the land (כל הארץ) , and from there Yahweh scattered (פֿוין) them upon the surface of all the land (כל הארץ)		

Scattered Table. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).

God’s preservation of a remnant (Noah and sons) out of the flood becomes an anticipation of God’s preservation of a remnant (Abraham and sons) out of the scattering of Babylon. And all of these patterns are

designed to anticipate the future preservation of a remnant out of the exile of Judah to Babylon.

Rebellion	Divine Justice	New Eden
Genesis 3-6a Three cycles of rebellion: 1. Garden folly (Gen. 3) 2. Cain: Next generation sins (Gen. 4) 3. Lemek: Next generation sins (Gen. 4) 4. Cosmic rebellion (Gen. 6)	Gen 6:5-8:19 • Flood of divine justice • A remnant (שאר) seed is preserved through the water: Noah + 3 sons (Shem!)	Genesis 8:20-9:17 • Remnant ascends to new Eden • Sacrifices / worship • New Eden blessing / covenant
Genesis 9:18-11:7 Three cycles of rebellion: 1. Garden folly (Gen. 9:20-21) 2. Ham: Next generation sins (Gen. 9:22-28) 3. Nimrod: Next generation sins: Gen. 10:9 4. Cosmic rebellion (Gen. 11:1-7)	Genesis 11:8-32 • Scattering of divine justice • A remnant seed is preserved through the scattering: Terah + 3 sons (Abraham!)	Genesis 12:1-10 • Remnant ascends to new Eden • Sacrifices / worship • New Eden blessing / covenant
Genesis 12-2 Kings Many cycles of rebellion: 1. More garden folly 2. Next generation repeats constantly 3. Cosmic rebellions abound	Genesis 12-2 Kings • Israel's exile due to divine justice • A remnant seed is preserved through the exile (Isa. 4, 11, 40-66) • New sons for Abraham and Sarah (see Isa. 54; Jer. 31)	Isaiah-Jeremiah-Ezekiel • The 12 remnant ascends to new Eden (Isaiah 40-55) • Sacrifices / worship (Isa. 60-62) • New Eden blessing / covenant (Isa. 65-66)
<i>Cycles of Rebellion Macro Design Pattern. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom Noah to Abraham (2020).</i>		

Noah's Failure, Ham's Fall, and the Division of the Brothers (Gen. 9:20-24)

Noah's Foolish Failure

This cryptic and disturbing story has been placed here so that the reader sees a replay of the twin stories of folly and rebellion in Genesis 3-4.

Genesis 9:18-27: Noah's Folly and Ham's "Fall"	Genesis 2-3: Humanity's "Fall"
9:20 Noah was a "man of the ground" (אִישׁ הָאֲדָמָה)	3:23 Humanity "works the ground" (לְעַבֵּד אֶת הָאֲדָמָה)
9:20-21 Noah drinks from his vineyard which he planted (נָטַע)	3:5-6 Humanity eats from the tree which Yahweh planted 2:8 (נָטַע)
9:22 Ham saw (וִירָא) the nakedness of his father	3:7 Humanity's eyes are opened to see (וִירָאוּ) their own nakedness
9:22 Ham told (וַיַּגִּד) his two brothers about his father's nakedness (עֲרוּת אָבִיו)	3:11 "Who told (יִגִּיד) you that you were naked (עֲרוֹם)?"
9:23 Shem and Japheth cover (כָּסוּ) their father's nakedness (עֲרוּהוּ), so they do not see (רָאוּ) it	3:7 "And they knew they were naked, and they sewed leaves of a fig tree and made for themselves coverings (חִגְרָה)" 3:21 God makes animal skin (עוֹר) coverings for humanity's nakedness
9:24 Noah awoke from his wine and he knew (וַיֵּדַע) what his son had done to him (עָשָׂה לוֹ)	3:7, 13 The eyes of the two of them were opened and they knew (וַיֵּדְעוּ) they were naked ... "What is this you have done (עָשִׂיתָ)?"
9:25 Canaan is cursed (אֲרוּר)	3:14, 17 The serpent and the ground are cursed (אֲרוּר)
Noah's Folly and Humanity's Fall. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

This strange story depicts Noah's folly as a moral failure rather than a rebellion. Getting drunk does not violate a divine command as such, but it is a foolish act that exposes him to danger. In fact, this text is the first of many in the Hebrew Bible that shows the perils of alcohol abuse and its foolish, self-humiliating consequences.

Proverbs 23:31-35 Instructor's Translation

³¹ Do not see that (כִּי + רָאָה) the wine (יַיִן) is red (אָדָם),
when it offers its eye (עֵינַיִם) in the cup,
when it walks (יִתְהַלֵּךְ) down smoothly.

³² At the last it bites like a snake (נָחָשׁ)
and stings like a viper.

³³ Your eyes will see (עֵינַיִם + רָאָה) strange things
and your heart will utter perverse things.

34 You will be like one lying down in the heart of the seas,
 lying on top of the mast.
 35 “They hit me,” you will say, “but I’m not hurt!
 They beat me up, but I don’t know (יָדַעַ) it!
 When can I wake up, so I can find another drink?”

This poem about wine in [Proverbs 23:31-35](#) is saturated with vocabulary from the Eden narrative as well as the flood narrative. This poet is aware of the wine//deception//snake design pattern that links Genesis 3 and 9:20-21 together in a parallel relationship.

Ham’s Crime Against His Family

The above link between Ham looking upon his father’s nakedness as a result of Noah’s eating the fruit of the garden is an excellent example of “dynamic analogy.” For more information, see Jonathan Grossman’s article “Dynamic Analogies in Esther.”

Adam, Eve, and Cain	Noah and Ham
Genesis 3 Eve sees the fruit and eats with Adam “and they knew that they were naked ”	Genesis 9:20-21 Noah eats of the fruit of the vineyard, becomes exposed ... “and he knew what his son did to him”
Genesis 4 The son Cain is angry and separates from his brother to kill him	Genesis 9:22-24 The son Ham sees the nakedness of his father and separates from his brothers in a shameful act
<i>Ham’s Crime Echoes Genesis 3 and 4. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).</i>	

Noah repeats, in his own way, the folly of Adam and Eve because eating the garden fruit leads to nakedness and exposure to humiliation.

Ham, however, repeats both the folly of Adam and Eve (since they set the paradigm for human folly) and the rebellion of Cain in the heinous act that divides the brotherhood. This is why Ham’s story activates the vocabulary of both Genesis 3 and 4. He is replaying the fundamental human folly, as well as choosing (like Cain) his own destructive path that will ruin his family.

There is also an important connection here with Ezekiel 18 and Jeremiah 31, where the prophets deconstruct the proverb that “the parents eat sour grapes, but the children’s teeth suffer” ([Ezek. 18:2](#); [Jer. 31:29](#)).

The prophets and Genesis 1-11 disagree with this proverb. Each generation may live within the environment created by the sin of their ancestors, but it is their own choices that create their ultimate destiny. This argument in Ezekiel and Jeremiah is addressed to an exilic audience, and it’s likely that this same theme in Genesis 1-11 is compositionally related.

The same dynamics are at work in the David narrative, where his sin with Bathsheba (Gen. 3) and his murder of Uriah (Gen. 4) is repeated by his three children: Amnon rapes Tamar (Gen. 3) and Absalom murders Amnon (Gen. 4).

“Ham, the father of Canaan” (Gen. 9:18, 22)

Why does the narrator tell us twice in this cryptic story that Ham is the father of Canaan? It’s part of a compositional strategy to compare Ham’s line to Cain’s line because Cain gave birth to a line ending with Lemek and his three sons.

Cain's Four Sons (Gen. 4:18-22)	Ham's Four Sons (Gen. 9:18-22; 10:6)
+1 Lemek 1. Yabal 2. Yubal 3. Tubal-Cain	1. Cush 2. Egypt/Mizraim 3. Put +1 Canaan
“Yabal, the father of (אָבִי) tent-dwellers and livestock” (Gen. 4:20)	“Ham, the father of (אָבִי) Canaan” (Gen. 9:18)
“Yubal, the father of (אָבִי) all handlers of lyre and flute” (Gen 4:21)	“Ham, the father of (אָבִי) Canaan” (Gen. 9:22)
Cain's and Ham's Sons. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).	

In Cain’s line, the three sons of Lemek are grouped together by similar names so that Lemek stands out, and he is the one who replays the sin of Cain. Ham’s line is inverted so that Canaan is the fourth one who sticks out.

In this way, the narrator hints that just as Cain’s own murderous act was magnified by his descendant Lemek, so also will Ham’s shameful act be magnified by his descendant Canaan. And, of course, Leviticus 18 and 20 make this crystal clear.

The Sin of Ham Against His Father (Gen. 9:22-24)

Two key questions have arisen in the history of interpretation of this cryptic story. For more information, see “Noah’s Nakedness and the Curse on Canaan” from *Journal of Biblical Literature* (Hahn and Bergsma, 2005).

1. What did Ham do to his father in the tent?
2. Why does Ham’s action result in a curse on his son Canaan?

Numerous interpretations of Ham’s crime against his father throughout history have attempted to answer these two questions.

Voyeurism

Ham's offense was his shameful gaze at the indecent exposure of his father. This view has simplicity as a strength, but it doesn't explain the gravity of the action or why Noah responds with such ferocity.

Paternal incest (i.e., rape)

Ham's offense was to sexually abuse his father, a shocking act. This view is built on an important insight, that the words "to look at the nakedness of ..." (ערוה + ראה) are a biblical Hebrew figure of speech that refers to sexual intercourse. The phrase is also used of Noah in his tent, that his nakedness "was uncovered" (גלה).

Leviticus 20:17 NASB

If there is a man who takes his sister, his father's daughter or his mother's daughter, so that **he sees her nakedness** (ערוה + ראה) and **she sees his nakedness** (ראה + ערוה), it is a disgrace; and they shall be cut off in the sight of the sons of their people. He has **uncovered his sister's nakedness** (גלה + ערוה); he bears his guilt.

Leviticus 18:6 NASB

None of you shall approach any blood relative of his to **uncover nakedness** (גלה + ערוה); I am the LORD.

Ezekiel 16:36 NASB

Thus says the Lord GOD, "Because your lewdness was poured out and your **nakedness uncovered** (ערוה + גלה) through your harlotries with your lovers and with all your detestable idols, and because of the blood of your sons which you gave to idols ..."

See also Ezekiel 22:10, 23:10, 23:18, 23:29. In all of these texts, the phrase "to see/uncover nakedness" means to have sex with someone.

This interpretation also makes sense of the wording in Genesis 9:24 that Noah woke up "and he knew what his son had done to him."

This interpretation also makes sense of the accompanying imagery of wine, vineyards, and tents, all of which can have erotic associations (such as David getting Uriah drunk with wine so that he'll have sex with Bathsheba in 2 Sam. 11:11-13, or the erotic garden imagery in the Song of Songs 1:2, 4, 6; 2:13, 15; 5:1; 6:11, etc.).

The paternal incest view also provides a motive for Ham, namely, to shame and dishonor his father in an act of sexual domination, thereby displacing his father and brothers as the head of the family.

This story also forms an inclusio frame around the entire flood narrative as it matches another story of illicit boundary-crossing sex: the sons of God and the human daughters in Genesis 6:1-4.

This story also links forward verbally and thematically to the destruction of Sodom and Gomorrah (which is packed with verbal allusions to the flood). That story also begins and ends with stories of illicit sex.

- Genesis 19:4-5: The men of Sodom gather to gang rape the two angels.
- Genesis 19:30-38: Lot's daughters get him drunk with wine and have sex with their father, resulting in the birth of the Moabites and Ammonites.

This illicit sex theme forms the same inverted inclusio around the Sodom and Gomorrah narrative that Genesis 6:1-4 and Genesis 9:20-24 form around the flood story.

	Flood	Sodom
Before	Angels (Males) → Humans (Females)	Humans (Males) → Angels (Males)
After	Son (Males) → Father (Males)	Daughters (Females) → Father (Males)
<i>Flood and Sodom Thematic Framing. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Noah to Abraham (2020).</i>		

The **flood** concludes with a view toward the offspring of Ham (**Canaanites**), and the **Sodom and Gomorrah** narrative concludes with a view toward the offspring of Lot (**Ammonites and Moabites**), and both stories are associated somehow with incest (גיוי עריות).

Based on all these factors, it's likely the biblical authors expected readers to make the connection to the paternal incest interpretation. But there is a final alternative to the paternal incest interpretation that potentially carries even more explanatory power.

Maternal Incest

In this view, Ham actually had sex with his mother, not his father Noah. The connections between this story and Leviticus 18 force the reader to take a closer look at these two chapters.

Leviticus 18 opens in a way that clearly shows awareness of the story of Ham in Genesis 9.

Leviticus 18:1-8 NASB*

¹ Then the LORD spoke to Moses, saying,

² "Speak to the sons of Israel and say to them, 'I am Yahweh your God.

³ You shall not do what is done in the land of **Egypt** where you lived, nor are you to do what is done in the land of **Canaan** where I am bringing you; you shall not walk in their statutes ...

⁵ So you shall keep my statutes and my judgments, by which a man may live if he does them; I am the LORD.

⁶ None of you shall approach any blood relative of his to **uncover nakedness** (גילה + ערוה); I am the LORD.

⁷ You shall not **uncover the nakedness of your father**, it is the **nakedness of your mother**. She is your mother; you are not to **uncover her nakedness**.

⁸ You shall not uncover the **nakedness of your father's wife**; it is your **father's nakedness**."

*Key Words Adapted by Teacher

The logic here is very clear and is based on the covenant concept of marriage expressed in Genesis 2:24. When the two become one flesh, they are, so to speak, each other's flesh, so to have sex with one is to have sex with the other.

Leviticus 18:8 is very explicit: to "uncover the nakedness of your father" means "to have sex with your mother."

It cannot be a coincidence that the first example in Leviticus 18, a chapter entirely about avoiding family incest, is about one's father and mother. And this is right after the mention of "what is done in the land of Canaan."

This view is also confirmed by numerous later design patterns, where sons attempt to shame or gain a position of authority over their father by sleeping with their wife (or wives).

- Reuben sleeps with Bilhah, his father's slave-wife (Gen. 35:22)
- Absalom sleeps with his father's harem (2 Sam. 16:21-22)
- Adonijah's attempt with sleep with David's slave-wife Abishag (1 Kgs. 2:13-25)

This view also provides a motive for Noah to curse Ham's son Canaan instead of Ham himself because the text implies that Canaan is the son of this illicit sexual act with Noah's wife.

"Noah becomes drunk and disrobes in the tent in preparation for intercourse with his wife, but is incapacitated by his drunkenness (v. 21). Ham enters and 'sees his father's nakedness,' that is, engages in relations with his father's wife (v. 22a). He exits and informs his brothers of his grasp at familial power (v. 22b), perhaps producing an article of clothing as proof of his claim. The brothers, in turn, act with excessive filial deference and piety in returning 'the garment' to their humiliated father, avoiding not only the figurative 'seeing of the fathers nakedness' (i.e., maternal incest) but the literal as well. In the aftermath of the event, Noah curses the product of Ham's illicit union, namely, Canaan, and blesses Shem and Japheth for their piety."

Bergsma, J. and Hahn, S. (2005). "Noah's Nakedness and the Curse on Canaan (Genesis 9:20-27)." *Journal of Biblical Literature*, 124 (1). 38-39.

This explains why, in the narrative, Ham is twice identified as "the father of Canaan." This is a signal to the reader that the story is about how Ham became the father of Canaan.

This provides a more precise parallel to the story about the daughters of Lot in Genesis 19:30-37, where a child takes advantage of their parent's drunkenness so they can produce offspring.

This interpretation also provides a parallel origin story of the Canaanites, Moabites, and Ammonites, who are Israel's neighbors and adversaries.

Reflection Question

What are some of the specific parallels between Genesis 2-4 and Genesis 9:18-24?